



ancestors back over 4,000 years. There are many different Miao clans living in this mountainous area, each with its own individual characteristics and dialects. All, however, share a basic culture that has

clearly developed from a common root. The Miao are known for their beautiful arts and crafts, particularly their fabric designs, and for their spectacular festivals and celebrations filled with song and dance.



THE SHENG

A popular instrument in the Miao culture is the *sheng*, a wind instrument made from a bundle of different lengths of bamboo. It can produce chords as well as single notes and is thought to have been used up to 3,000 years ago in China.

Farming

Much of the Miao area is hilly or mountainous, drained by several rivers. The weather is mild with plenty of rain so farming is a large part of the people's lives. The staple crop is rice, supplemented by corn, wheat, and all kinds of fruit and vegetables. Men mainly do the farming and hunting while women raise livestock and keep the home.

THE DRAGON



Many Miao still follow their traditional religion. They believe that spirits in the shape of dragons protect them, and often decorate fabrics with the beautiful, mythical creatures.

Traditionally the headdress was solid silver but these days only the smaller ornaments tend to be.

SILVER JEWELS

Women's headdresses have special importance in Miao culture. When a girl is born, her family starts to save money to buy silver head ornaments that are worn for special occasions. Each clan has a slightly different designs and at festivals the women dance in them, showing off their family's wealth.

